

LITTLE BLUE BOOK NO. 1431
Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

How to Read and Correct Proof

Lloyd E. Smith

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK HOW TO READ
AND CORRECT PROOF ***

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Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

How to Read and Correct Proof

Lloyd E. Smith

HALDEMAN-JULIUS PUBLICATIONS

GIRARD, KANSAS

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Haldeman-Julius Company

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HOW TO READ AND CORRECT PROOF

WHAT IS A PROOF?

A *proof*, in the parlance of printer or publisher, is an impression of type which shows how the matter will look when printed. A proof is made, or *pulled*, so that it can be read for errors, omissions, or faults of typography or style. It is the work of the *proofreader* to give the proof careful reading, marking all errors or alterations clearly so that the printer can follow them quickly and correctly. Proofreading is one job which must be done well, and which permits no excuses—that is, if a proofreader does not correct an error, he can offer no excuse: he overlooked it, that's all!

Proofreading is of two kinds. The publisher's or printer's proofreader reads proof as a steady occupation. All matter set in type, whether for newspapers, magazines, or books, or simply job work, must be read by someone to see that it is O. K. The professional proofreader is specially trained for his work. He catches errors that the average reader would probably overlook in the casual reading that is only for pastime.

After the professional proofreader has read the proof, and given it his O. K., if the matter is for a book, or, sometimes, if it is for a magazine, the proof is sent to the author. Authors are not always as expert at proofreading as they should be, but they can usually catch some things which ought to be changed. Sometimes the proofreader has marked queries for the author's attention, queries about matters on which the proofreader has no data or which seemed to him strange or possibly incorrect. The author must note and answer all proofreader's queries.

Proof may be read several times, depending on the degree of accuracy desired. Newspaper proofs are often read only once, because of the speed with which the newspaper must be produced. Authors of newspaper material seldom have a chance to read the proof. Proof of magazine material is usually read at least twice; for some magazines, which are especially careful, the proof is read more than twice, always by different readers. Sometimes the editor, or one of his assistants, gives the magazine proofs a final reading, after the proofreaders have given them an O. K. Proofs of books are read several times: first, by the printer's proofreader,

who eliminates most of the glaring errors; second, by one or more of the publisher's proofreaders, whose duty it is to see that the type is made as correct in every way as it is possible to make it; third, by the author, who must answer any proofreader's queries, and make any corrections which have been overlooked; fourth, by various authorities or friends of the author, particularly if the book is technical or mathematical—sometimes this reading is gratuitous, though occasionally it may be paid for; fifth, if the highest possible accuracy is desired, and the probable profits on the book justify this additional expense, by an editorial proofreader on the publisher's staff.

Even after all these readings, the final published work may contain a few errors. To err is very human, and errors are extremely difficult to eliminate. It is hardly possible to publish a work of any length that is absolutely free from errors of any kind. If you look sharp, you will probably find a few typographical errors in this Little Blue Book, though it has been read carefully at least four times, by different readers.

Errors that have persisted until the work is published have often been ludicrous. Some errors of this kind are famous. *Golden Book*, a magazine, has conducted for some years a department called "Why Editors Leave Home," in which are collected each month actual errors that have appeared in newspapers or magazines, in spite of the proofreaders.

Proofreaders have not existed as such from the time printing was first invented. Scholars constantly wish they had! It was computed by Sir Theodore Martin that the typographical errors in the First Folio edition of Shakespeare total nearly 20,000—a number which is two and a quarter percent of all the words in the book. Many of these errors have caused scholarly controversies without end.

In the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, indeed, authors were prone to shirk the arduous duties of proofreading. When their publishers submitted proof sheets of their work, they passed them around among their friends and acquaintances, quite blithely accepting the O. K. of these casual and more than often careless readers! Indeed, this custom was outdone in indifference by the universities and colleges, where accuracy would seem to have been at a premium. University material was corrected by the public at large! The proof sheets were posted on bulletin boards, and anyone passing

by could inspect them. If errors were noted, the passer-by was supposed to inform the authorities.

But as printing grew into “the art preservative of all arts,” it became more necessary to eliminate errors. Proofreading became a definite occupation. Scholars and men of letters were sometimes paid to read proofs. One famous proofreader was Alexander Cruden (1701-1770), famous for his *Concordance to the English Bible*; he was for some years “corrector of the press” in Wild Court; in 1729 he was a reader for the 10th Earl of Derby; after 1740 he was definitely a proofreader, enhancing the accuracy of several editions of Greek and Latin classics. Indeed, Cruden became known as “Alexander the Corrector,” but he interpreted this title to include also correction of morals, and played the part of an intermittent reformer.

Another famous proofreader was William Julius Mickle (1735-1788), a Scottish poet. He started out as a brewer, but his interest in literature caused him to neglect his business, and he became bankrupt. He was appointed proofreader for the Clarendon Press, one of the most famous of English printshops. Mickle is remembered chiefly for his translation of the Portuguese *Lusiad* of Camoëns; it earned him a public and royal reception when he visited Portugal in 1779. Sir Walter Scott is reputed to have founded the plot of his novel *Kenilworth* on a ballad by Mickle entitled *Cumnor Hall*.

Oliver Goldsmith, author of *She Stoops to Conquer* and *A Deserter's Village*, was another famous writer who saw service as a proofreader. So did Dr. Samuel Johnson, of the first English Dictionary, perpetually remembered in Boswell's fascinating biography.

“Times, however, have changed,” says the *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, since, “as the elder D'Israeli wrote, ‘it became the glory of the learned to be correctors of the press to eminent printers,’ and today in every printing office the proofreader is found—an unobtrusive functionary, known to publishers, authors, editors, and journalists, but for the most part unknown to the general reading public; a functionary who does useful, often valuable, and always indispensable work. The influence of good proofreading upon the character of book, newspaper and general printing is too often underrated. The celebrated old printing offices and the foremost of the modern ones owe their reputation for good workmanship largely to the

excellence and thoroughness of the work done in their reading-rooms, for no perfection of paper, ink, machining or binding can atone for bad or slipshod typography.”

Charles Dickens wrote a tribute to the proofreader, as follows:

I know from some slight practical experience what the duties of correctors of the press are, and how these duties are usually discharged. And I can testify here, that they are not mechanical—that they are not mere matters of manipulation and routine; but that they require from those who perform them much natural intelligence, much superadded cultivation, considerable readiness of reference, quickness of resource, an excellent memory and a clear understanding. And I must gratefully acknowledge that I have never gone through the sheets of any book I have written without having had presented to me by the corrector of the press something I had overlooked—some slight inconsistency into which I had fallen—some little lapse I had made—in short, without having set down in black and white some unquestionable indication that I had been closely followed in my work by a patient and trained mind, and not merely by a skilful eye. In this declaration I have not the slightest doubt that the great body of my brother and sister writers would, as a plain act of justice, heartily concur.

Indeed, Dickens had no less a corroborator than Robert Browning, who wrote:

I have had every opportunity of becoming acquainted with, and gratefully acknowledging, the extreme service rendered to me; and, if mine be no exceptional case, the qualifications of readers and correctors are important indeed.

In England there is a trade union of proofreaders. In the United States proofreaders, when responsible to the printers, are members of the Typographical Union. If editorial proofreaders, they need not necessarily be members of any union. The British Association of Correctors of the Press was founded in 1854 and is still in existence. Some American cities have proofreaders’ societies. American proofreaders as a class, it should be pointed out, are largely women.

THE COPY AND HOW IT IS SET AND PROVED

Manuscript sent to the printer for setting in type is called *copy*. The copy, before being sent to the typesetter, is marked to show how it is to be set: size of type, length of line, styles of type, initials, headings, and so on. It is the duty of the editor, or whoever prepares the copy for the press, to mark these details. Part of the duty of the proofreader is to see to it that the instructions on the copy are closely and correctly followed by the printer.

Copy should be carefully *edited* before being sent to the printer. By this is meant correction of misspelled words, mispunctuation, or any other grammatical or literary fault. The copy should be edited, also, to conform to an established *style*. By style is meant the policy of the publishing house sponsoring the work, as, for example, that Negro should always begin with a capital N (one of the idiosyncrasies of the style of Haldeman-Julius Publications). Many words may be correctly spelled in two ways—consider *gray* and *grey*, *skeptic* and *sceptic*, *honor* and *honour*, *theatre* and *theater*, *gruesome* and *grewsome*, etc. Consistency in spelling these words is part of the style, and consistency throughout a particular book or magazine should by all means be maintained.

Printers are supposed to *follow copy*—that is, they must set the matter exactly as it appears in the copy. Sometimes, as on newspapers, typesetters are supposed to make any necessary changes in the spelling or form of words to conform to the established style. An eminent editor once said that the printer should follow the copy even if it took him out of the window! However, a typesetter is likely to correct an obvious mistake in the copy, so if, for any reason, it is desirable to have an unusual form or misspelling set as written, it is necessary to write in the margin of the copy: *Follow*. This tells the typesetter that the matter is to stand as written.

If the copy has not been edited before being sent to the printer, then the task of the proofreader is much more arduous. He must not only read to correct typographical errors, watch for omissions (called *outs*), eliminate defective type, wrong fonts, and so on, but he must read the proof with an

eye to style, and particularly consistency. He must see that *today* is always spelled either with or without a hyphen, not letting the word pass with a hyphen on one page and without a hyphen on the next. Punctuation must be closely watched, for many authors are careless about punctuation.

Of course, it is more expensive to read proof for style than it is to have the copy edited in the first place. Sometimes it is necessary, however. The proofreader must exercise judgment, nevertheless. He should be careful not to make changes which necessitate resetting too much text matter.

Fewer mistakes are made in setting type today than used to be the rule, for nearly always today the copy is typewritten. Properly, all copy for the printer should be typewritten, and double-spaced. If the copy is clearly typewritten there need never be any disputes or queries to the author about the interpretation of his handwriting. Queries to the author on this point were formerly very common.

Today, too, the typesetting machine has taken the place of composition by hand. When printers set all type by hand, the chance of error was much greater, though each printer was supposed to *read his stick*—that is, read each line as he set it, to catch any obvious errors at once. There was a time when printers had to correct their mistakes on their own time; they were particularly careful not to make many mistakes in those days. However, any printer who makes above a certain average of errors today is likely to lose his job.

Typesetting machines are of several kinds. Two well-known names are the Linotype and the Intertype, which are alike in that both of them set type and cast it a line at a time (hence the name, *linotype*, “line o’ type”). The typesetter uses a keyboard similar to that on a typewriter, except that capital letters have separate keys from the small letters. Usually, each *mat* (matrix; the brass mold of the letter, several of which in one line are used to cast the line of type) in a linotype *font* (the complete assortment of letters, figures, and other characters, necessary to set matter in type) has on it the molds for two characters: roman and *italic*. (The word “roman” is here set in roman type; the word “italic” in italic type.) Thus, the mat for small “a” would have on it the molds for “a” and “*a*,” and that for capital “A” would have on it the molds for “A” and “*A*.” A special device on the machine enables the operator to cast whichever form is desired. One letter, one word, or an

entire line or series of lines can be cast in italic type from the same mats, set on the same keyboard, as those used for roman type of any particular size and style.

Sometimes, instead of italic, the font has **boldface** (or **fullface**), which is blacker than roman, and does not slant like italic. (The word is here set in **boldface** type). The same font of type cannot have boldface and italic and roman; the possible combinations are roman and italic, roman and boldface, or boldface and italic-boldface. Occasionally a mat will cast italic or boldface when it is not desired, and this makes an error for the proofreader to catch. Such an error occurs in the word proofreader in the preceding sentence. (Note: to make sure the operator setting this book would cast that italic “o” in that word, it was necessary to mark it *follow*.)

When linotype or intertype fonts are made, it is customary to provide SMALL CAPITALS (the words are here set in *small caps*, as they are usually called) with roman-italic fonts. These additional characters (just a few of them, so that it is not possible with average fonts to set more than a word or two at a time in small caps) are provided on the figures, punctuation marks, ligatures, where italics are on the letters of the alphabet. Small caps are not shown on the keyboard; the operator has to know which keys to strike, from memory. If the operator fails to make the necessary change in his mats to cast small caps, a strange mixture results. Thus, if the word few is set in small caps, and fails to cast as such, it looks like this: 65ffl!

The proofreader knows whether the matter he is reading is set on a machine that casts a whole line of type at a time. This is important in checking corrections, because whenever a correction is made in a line, the entire line must be reset and recast. The operator might, therefore, correct the word all right, but might make a new error in some other word. In checking corrected proofs the reader must read the entire line in every case.

The Monotype is a typesetting machine which casts each letter separately, so that the resulting composition is much the same as handset type. When corrections are made in matter set by the Monotype, the printer picks out the necessary single characters from a type-case, and inserts them by hand. Monotype composition is somewhat more expensive than Linotype or Intertype composition, and is consequently much less used. It

has to be used, however, wherever there is a great variety of types or characters in the same line, as in many textbooks, foreign languages, etc.

Headings in large type are often set by hand even today. Initials, rules, borders, and so on, are inserted by hand in or around the machine composition. The machine operator sets the straight matter, as marked on the copy. A printer then takes this, after it has been given a first proofreading, and *makes it up* into the necessary final arrangement.

Text matter is first proved on *galleys*. The galley is a shallow tray in which the type is placed for filing away on shelves, awaiting correction. This first proof is called the *galley proof*: it is a trial impression made on strips of paper about two feet long, as a rule, the paper being wide enough to accommodate the width of the type as set, and to leave generous margins on both sides for the proofreader to mark the corrections. The galley proofs are numbered consecutively.

The first galley proofs are read by the printer's proofreader, and corrected. The corrected proofs are marked for *revise*. The proofreader carefully checks the corrections, marking any new errors, or any errors that were overlooked. When the galley proofs are O. K. according to the first proofreader, they are delivered to the next person who is to read them, together with the copy. When the second proofreader gives the proofs an O. K., the proofs may then be sent to the author, or to whoever is to read them next.

After the galley proofs have been given an O. K. by the regular readers, the type is *paged*, if it is for a book or a magazine. Initials, illustrations, diagrams, etc., are inserted wherever indicated. Each page is *justified* (made to the right size, even to the fraction of an inch), and the page numbers and running heads are added. The page numbers are known as *folios*. Sometimes the page numbers are on the same line with the page headings, as in this Little Blue Book, but they may be by themselves at the bottom of each page, either at the outer corner or centered (in the middle). *Captions* for the illustrations or diagrams are set and inserted also. *Page proofs* are then pulled, and sent to the proofreader, whose duty it is to see that everything is O. K. for going on the press. It is page proofs that are usually sent to the author, unless he particularly requests galley proofs, or unless it

is likely that he will make several changes, as in a timely work which may have to be revised right up to the minute of going to press.

On newspapers proofreading is much more hastily done than anywhere else. Frequently the machine operators check their own corrections—that is, they read each slug (or line) as it is cast, recasting it if any error is noted. It is then taken for granted that the lines are O. K., and they are slipped into proper place and the matter is considered *clean*.

If for any reason, or by accident, type is printed without being proofread it is said to be *railroaded*. Type that has been O. K.'d by all the proofreaders is called *clean*, or simply O. K.

When all the matter is finally O. K. for a book or magazine, it is locked up for the presses, if it is to be printed from the type, or for the electrotypewriter, if plates are to be made first. Electrotypes are usually used for books, and for magazines of large circulation because there is no chance of dropping the forms and mixing up the type (then called *pied*), and plates are much easier to handle. Copper-faced electrotypes also wear much longer than linotype metal or cast type. Stereotype metal, however, used for casting the semi-circular plates for rotary presses, is much harder and lasts longer than linotype. Linotype can be used directly only on so-called *flat-bed* presses. After the plates are made, the type is usually *killed* (thrown into a melting pot, and melted up, cast into *pigs* or small blocks, ready to be used again in the machines).

When the press form is ready, it is put on the press which is to turn out the printed sheets. A press proof is then pulled, showing the exact impression the press will turn out, as the form has been locked up. A reader whose duty it is to O. K. press proofs must go over this proof carefully. If it is from plates, he must see that they are in the right order and that they all show up well. The pressman must *make ready* on the form to give an even impression and eliminate any light or heavy places in the type. If the press proof is from type, the reader must be sure that no lines have been transposed while the type was handled when being put into the form; he must also check the order of pages, and watch to see that no initials (which are sometimes loosely inserted) have dropped out during the handling of the form. If the press proof is for color work, the reader's task is even more arduous; but this phase of printing is beyond the province of this little book.

HOW TO READ PROOF

Proof may be read by oneself alone, or with the assistance of a *copyholder*. If the proofreader reads alone, he must train himself to do several things at once. He must read slowly enough so that he can note that every word is spelled correctly; he must note the punctuation as he reads, seeing that it conforms to the requirements of good practice, and seeing also that it conveys the proper sense of the words; he must catch the sense of what he is reading, so that anything strange will cause him to consult the copy, perhaps finding an *out*—a word, a phrase, or a sentence omitted. In general, the task of the proofreader who cannot have the help of a copyholder is much more difficult than otherwise, if he is to do a good job.

With a copyholder, the proofreader usually makes two readings. First he reads the proof while the copyholder reads the copy aloud to him, calling out each mark of punctuation as well as all the words, capitalization, etc. For example, a copyholder reading proof on this book, would read the first sentence of this section as follows: “Proof may be read by oneself alone comma or with the assistance of a copyholder italicized period.” The copyholder would not necessarily mention that “proof” has a capital P, since that would be obvious if it begins a sentence. She calls the period, however, to show the end of the sentence.

The proofreader can work up a suitable code with his copyholder to save time and breath. The comma, semicolon, colon, and period may be called by their usual names. The question mark may be simply called “question,” and the exclamation point may be abbreviated to just “sclamation.” Parentheses may be called “paren,” and the close of the parentheses may be spoken as “unparen.” Similarly with quotation marks: the first marks may be called “quote,” and the closing marks, “unquote.” If the marks are single quotation marks (for a quotation within another quotation, or perhaps alone, depending on style), they may be called, opening, “sing-quote,” and closing, “un-sing-quote.” For example, the preceding sentence might be read by a copyholder using this code, as follows: “If the marks are single quotation marks paren for a quotation within another quotation comma or

perhaps alone comma depending on style unparen comma they may be called comma opening comma quote sing hyphen quote comma unquote (if this is confusing, the proofreader may at this point consult the copy to be sure just what the word is) and closing comma quote un-sing hyphen quote period unquote.”

It is awkward always to say the word *italics* or *italicized*, when the copyholder meets such a word or words in the copy. One way to get around this is to arrange that as the copyholder speaks a word that is to be italicized she tap a pencil lightly. The pencil tap must come simultaneously with the utterance of the word that is to be in italics. For example, a copyholder would read the first sentence of this paragraph thus: “It is awkward always to say the word italics (pencil tap as “italics” is spoken) or italicized (pencil tap) comma, etc.” The proofreader knows instantly that *italics* and *italicized* are both to appear in italic type. Of course, if a single letter of a word is to be italicized, or if any special arrangement of type is confusing when spoken aloud, the proofreader may always consult the copy himself for verification. The copyholder should sit near at hand so that the proofreader may look at the copy if he wishes to do so, without delay or inconvenience.

After the proofreader has read the proof once with a copyholder, he should read it a second time silently. The first reading with the copyholder should eliminate the more obvious typographical errors, and also should catch any misinterpretations the printer may have made of the copy, including omissions or duplications. The second and silent reading should be devoted to checking up on spelling, punctuation, and general style. While the proofreader is occupied with silent reading, the copyholder, if not reading to some other proofreader, should make herself useful arranging galley proofs, transcribing corrections from one set of proofs to another (when this is desired), arranging or filing copy, keeping records of proof read, etc.

A proofreader on the staff of a publishing house should realize that he alone is responsible. The copyholder can never be blamed for the proofreader’s shortcomings. If the copyholder does not speak clearly, the proofreader must ask her to repeat. The copyholder should always read from the copy—never from the proof. If, in long jobs, it ever becomes advisable to change about, the proofreader may, very slowly and distinctly, read *from the proof* to the copyholder. But this should not be done except in

extreme necessity, as for resting during long readings that must be forced through in minimum time.

A proofreader should be swift *and* accurate. Never sacrifice accuracy for speed. If a proofreader is compelled by circumstances to read proof in less time than he feels he should take to do a good job, he should do the best he can, but make it clear that his O. K. in such limited time does not mean the accuracy that it normally does (or should!).

The proofreader's responsibility extends beyond the copy. The fact that an error in copy is reproduced in type does not excuse the proofreader. It is his job to note the error. If he has any doubt whether it should be corrected, he should make a query to the author, or to the editor, or take it up with someone in editorial authority. Matters of fact, such as dates; names of people, places, books, etc.; quotations from other works; statistics; etc., should be checked by the proofreader with some authority other than the copy if possible. Authors (though it should not be tolerated!) are notoriously careless about such details. Often author and editor both fall into the habit of relying on the proofreader to catch and correct such slips. The proofreader's shoulders must be both broad and tireless! *Always*—if there is anything you, as a proofreader, do not understand, or think is incorrect, but which you lack the reference facilities to check, *query it* and see that the query reaches the author, editor, or someone in authority.

If you are an author, and proofs are sent to you, *read them*. It is due yourself in all fairness, even if you do not care to do it for your publisher and, ultimately, for your reader. *Always* note carefully any queries the proofreaders may have marked for your attention; *answer all queries* on the proof, either by crossing out the query (do NOT erase any queries) and writing "O. K.," or by crossing out the query and making the necessary correction. Do not take these queries as insults to your intelligence. Be grateful for the care which proofreaders have exercised to protect you and the publisher from committing what might be errors. Finally, simply answer the queries by marking them O. K. or making corrections: *do not write a message on the subject*. Consider how Dickens and Browning appreciated the work of the proofreaders on their books: go thou and do likewise.

PROOFREADER'S MARKS

When correcting or marking proof, make use of the marks reproduced on the following page which are understood by all printers and machine operators. The marks should be used with care. Always be sure that your correction is clear, or that you have marked a change or alteration so that it will be understood immediately.

There are two ways of marking proof. If the work is fussy, as on textbooks, expensive cloth-bound books, and so on, the proofreader may go very slowly. Corrections are usually marked within the line: a caret showing an omission, a line drawn through a letter to be deleted or for which some other letter or character is to be substituted, etc. The actual correction—mark for “delete,” letter or character to be inserted or substituted, punctuation to be inserted or substituted, etc.—is then put in the margin, either at the left or right, whichever is the more convenient. If there is more than one correction in one line, each correction in the margin should be separated from any other by a diagonal line. This method of marking proof is shown in the back of Webster’s New International Dictionary, and in Funk and Wagnalls New Standard Dictionary in the vocabulary under the word *proof*. It would be well for the student to study these plates.

<i>&</i> delete (take out)	<i>en</i> insert en-dash
<i>⌋</i> close up (no space)	<i>;</i> insert semicolon
<i>#</i> insert space	<i>⊙</i> insert colon
<i>⊗</i> delete and close up	<i>⊙</i> insert period
<i>□</i> indent one em	<i>tr</i> transpose
<i>[</i> move to left	<i>wf</i> wrong font
<i>]</i> move to right	<i>lc</i> lower case (small letter)
<i>⌋</i> move downward	<i>ital</i> set in italics or <u> </u> (underline)
<i>⌈</i> move upward	<i>rom</i> set roman
<i>^</i> insert (shown in margin)	<i>caps</i> set capitals or <u> </u> (underline)
<i>×</i> broken letter (reset)	<i>pc</i> set small capitals or <u> </u> (underline)
<i>^</i> insert comma	<i>stet</i> let stand (don't change)
<i>∩</i> insert apostrophe (or single quotes).	<i>ld></i> insert lead (space)
<i>∪</i> insert quotes	<i>9</i> turn right side up
<i>≡</i> straighten (horizontal)	<i>¶</i> paragraph
<i> </i> align (vertical)	<i>Vh</i> even spacing
<i>•</i> insert hyphen.	<i>?</i> insert question mark
<i>em</i> insert em-dash	<i>⊙</i> query to author
<i>b.f.</i> set boldface (fullface) or <i>bf</i> , or <i>ff</i> , or <i>roman</i> (underline)	<i>↓</i> push down space or lead

Proofs for book-publishers are usually to be marked *in ink*. The proofs are pulled on paper which will take ink without smearing or blotting. Proofs for newspapers are commonly marked rather hastily with pencil. Many proofreaders, working rapidly, do not follow the long-established proofreader's marks exactly. Instead of making a caret or line within the line, to show the exact spot of the correction, and writing the correction in the margin opposite the line, these proofreaders put their pencil where the correction belongs and *draw out* a line to the margin, placing the correction at the end of this guide-line. "Delete" is then indicated by simply putting a

“pig’s tail” (an upward curl, like the script letter *e*) on the end of the line so drawn out. The symbol used for “delete” by more carefully precise proofreaders is the Greek letter delta (script). The “pig’s tail” is all that remains of the curl in the Greek delta, in the markings of many modern proofreaders.

A word should be said—that, so far as this humble author knows, has never yet been said—about the samples of proofreading given in the dictionaries. In both Webster’s New International and the New Standard, in the short specimens shown, dozens of errors are marked. They are, if one may be frank, just *howlers*. To correct these specimens, many marks are necessary, and it is also necessary to reset the entire matter in each case, from first line to last. If a proofreader in practice were presented with such a dirty piece of type to read, he would, of course, not trouble to mark it. He would mark it “Kill,” and send the *copy* back to be reset! And what is more, the typesetter would probably lose his job!

Printer’s proofreaders sometimes indicate any corrections or alterations that are *changes from copy* by circling them. This shows the composing-room foreman that his typesetter is not responsible for *all* the errors marked. If this is not done, and many changes are made, the foreman might tell the typesetter to get his hat and coat and look elsewhere for work. A typesetter is expected to make some mistakes, but he is not by any means permitted to run wild.

It is difficult to state what is the average percentage of errors a proofreader may expect. In general, short lines (sixteen ems wide or less), contain fewer errors than long lines (20 to 30 or 40 ems), as is to be expected. Matter set in short lines is consequently easier to proofread. Straight text, set in clear roman type, is easier to read between the sizes of eight- and twelve-point, than is type smaller than eight or larger than twelve (or perhaps fourteen-point). The proofreader should adjust his time and attention accordingly. Matter set throughout in italics, or in small capitals or capitals, is usually somewhat harder to read carefully than clear roman type. Such matter should therefore be given more concentrated attention.

The manner of reading proof depends upon the idiosyncrasy of each reader. Good light, a comfortable chair, a desk at the right height—these are essentials. Some readers find it helpful to run a card down the page or

galley disclosing a line at a time. A proofreader of the author's acquaintance had the habit of rolling an octagonal pencil down the galleys, uncovering a line and pausing as each line was read. Other readers use no such guidance, but read as they would read a book, only more slowly.

A reader must develop a "proofreader's eye." The ordinary reader of papers or books reads much more rapidly than a proofreader can let himself read. The ordinary reader forms the habit of grasping entire words and groups of words. Frequently the eye of such a reader will accept the apparent form of a word for the word itself; this is shown by misreadings that everyone constantly makes. Many typographical errors persist in books, but few readers ever notice them there; though this is no excuse for proofreaders to leave them there! As a test for *you*, the reader of this book, at least three typographical errors have been allowed to stand in this paragraph up to this point—how many of them did you notice?

A few words may be helpful as to *wrong fonts*. A wrong font (marked "w.f.," or, often, "wf") is a letter of a type-style or size that does not belong. A wrong font may be an italic letter in roman type, an eight-point letter in seven- or nine-point type, a boldface letter in roman type, etc. If you are the first proofreader, reading directly after the matter is set, you must *call a wrong font to the attention of the typesetter immediately* (if it is machine composition). Otherwise the wrong font letter will persist throughout the matter at regular intervals. *Note:* An italic letter in roman type is a chance occurrence, and need not be called to the attention of the operator if italics are a part of the font; similarly with boldface wrong fonts. However, a boldface letter may get into an italic font of the same size and style—this should, of course, be called to the operator's attention. Some wrong fonts are exasperatingly difficult to detect: you must train your eyes to catch them. Familiarize yourself with type styles to help you in this.

Modern machine line-composition cannot have letters upside down—it is mechanically impossible. The proofreader's mark for an inverted letter, therefore, would be of use only in correcting handset or monotype composition. An entire line may, however, be inserted upside down, especially in revised proofs.

SOME POINTS TO REMEMBER

1. The proofreader can never have any excuse for failure to correct an error. Of course, he overlooked it—but that is no excuse! If reading with a copyholder, never allow the copyholder to assume responsibility. In any doubt, or in case a blurred word is met with in copy, the final decision rests with the proofreader.

2. Query everything which seems doubtful. But be discreet and considerate. A proofreader can make an idiot of himself with queries which are unjustified. Check everything you can yourself.

3. Put your initials at the top of every galley; or, if page proofs, on the first page. If the proof is read with a copyholder, place the copyholder's initials below yours. These initials, with those of any subsequent readers, should be copied on all subsequent proofs. This enables a superior to fix responsibility where it belongs.

4. If a proofroom is provided for your work, see that it is kept in order. If a particular copyholder is assigned to you, train him or her to keep things picked up, put reference books back in place when you are through with them, and so on. The copyholder should attend to all filing of proofs, copy, etc., unless a file-clerk is provided for this work.

5. Corrections on proof should be made *in ink*, unless the proofs are thrown away as corrected, when pencil may be permissible.

6. Remember that when reading page proofs, the running heads or folios must all be read separately. This should be done as a job by itself, after everything else about the page proofs has been checked. Page proofs sent to the author provide the last chance for queries to the author. The final O. K. on page proofs is the last chance the proofreader has to check any corrections or verify any facts.

7. If galley proofs are sent to the author, the copy must accompany them. The author should return this copy with the proofs, after he has read and marked them. If page proofs are sent to the author, following galley proofs, the foul (or marked) galley proofs should be sent with them. The author

should return *all* proofs as soon as convenient. If only page proofs are sent to the author, the copy should be sent with them.

8. Follow the style of the paper or publishing house which employs you as proofreader. However, if the author's preference violates the style-book, many publishers permit the author to have his way. Be sure you understand your employers' policy in this respect.

9. Consistency is a prime virtue in typesetting. It is part of your task as proofreader to see that it is maintained. If a style-sheet or style-book is lacking, the proofreader must content himself with maintaining a consistent style throughout one article, one magazine, or one book.

10. If the publishing house is a large one, the proofs are likely to be marked with the *job number* at the top of every galley. The copyholder should memorize this for each job and repeat this number at the beginning of every galley, so the proofreader can check it.

11. In checking revised proofs, the proofreader should make a checkmark or dot against each line as read, to be sure that none are omitted. If the corrections have necessitated runovers, these should be read with the copyholder, if one is available.

12. If you are a copyholder, learn how proof is read and marked. You can thus learn to be of the most help to your proofreader. Read slowly and distinctly. Slow up or stop whenever the reader puts his pen or pencil to paper to make a correction. Do not have to be asked to stop. Call the reader's attention to anything which seems to you to be wrong. Though the responsibility is not yours, your worthiness and usefulness depend upon your pride in your work. Copyholder and proofreader should work as a team, with the common aim of making the type as perfect as possible.

13. Books containing cuts or illustrations require special attention. The proofreader should indicate in the margin of galley proofs where the *first reference* to each cut or illustration occurs in the text. The reader of the page proofs must see that such cuts or illustrations are properly inserted, either in the text, or on separate pages facing the text-page containing the first reference. Usually plates (full page illustrations) are made to face a lefthand page. Often the author is requested to alter his text to make this possible. It

is *never* permissible for two adjacent plates to be printed on separate sheets, facing back to back, causing two blank pages to come together.

14. In marking queries for author or editor, be sure the point in question is made clear. Usually a question mark, placed in a circle, is enough. If not, write a few words explaining why the query is made.

15. Study books on typography. Learn what good taste in typography means. Familiarize yourself with the equipment of the composing-room where the matter you read is set. Do not mark characters or changes that your composing-room is not equipped to make.

16. If any correction is necessary in page proof, try to make the substituted matter fit the space exactly, so that no more than one line, or two at most, will have to be reset. The more lines that must be reset, the greater the expense, and the greater the chance of other errors being made.

17. An author should remember that changes from copy are likely to be charged to him at what they cost to make. Copy should never be sent to press unless it is as perfect as the author can make it. If the author is willing to pay for expensive changes—why, all right!

Transcriber's Note

The illustration of proofreader's marks was moved to the end of the paragraph in which it appeared. It was originally on page 24.

Spelling was retained as in the original except for the following changes:

Page [8](#): “for the 10th earl” to “for the 10th Earl”

Page [8](#): “as ‘Alexander the Corector’” to “as ‘Alexander the Corrector’”

Page [20](#): “that is to be” to “that is to be in”

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK HOW TO READ
AND CORRECT PROOF ***

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